



August CPI – Came in on our expectations

#inflation

#australia

#rba

#economicbulletinsaustralia

#inflation

By [Justin Smirk](#) & [Neha Sharma](#)

15:27 September 30 2026

Share

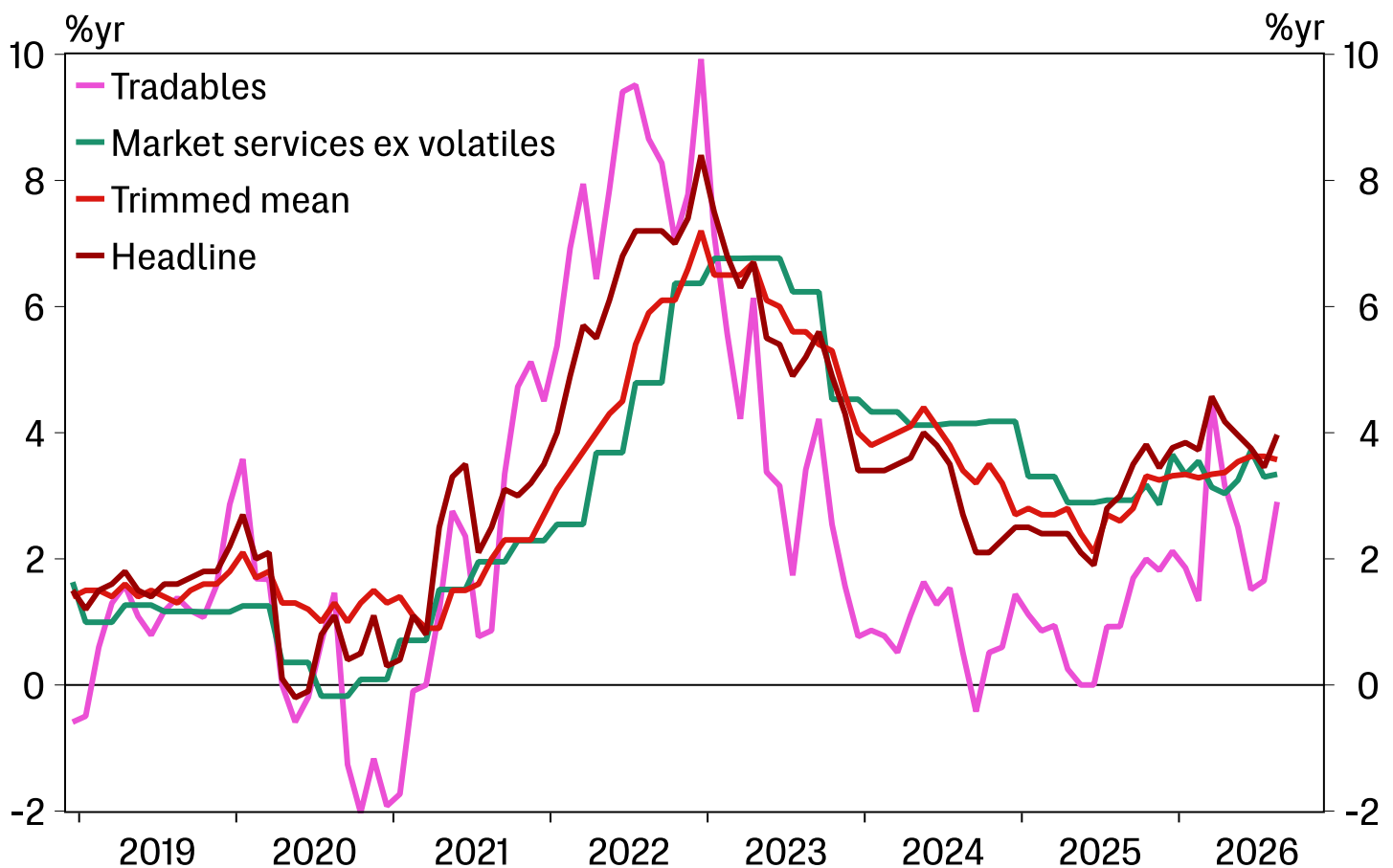
August Monthly CPI: Headline 0.4%*mth*/4.0%*yr*, Trimmed Mean 0.2%*mth*/3.6%*yr*. Market services ex volatile –0.4%*mth*/3.3%*yr*.



- The CPI rose 0.4% in August, spot on Westpac's expectation but a bit softer than market expectations of 0.5%. Due to base effects the annual pace picked up to 4.0%*yr* from 3.5%*yr*.

- Key factors driving the headline result were auto fuels (14.8%); games, toys & hobbies (10.2%) with rents providing a solid base (0.3%) while some offset was provided by both domestic (−4.9%) and international holiday travel & accommodation (−1.5%).
- Trimmed mean (TM) inflation printed 0.2% again bang on Westpac's expectation while the market was slightly higher at 0.3%. The annual pace was flat at 3.6%yr, the third month in a row at this pace, while the six-month annualise pace was steady at 3.9%yr.
- Key factors driving the TM print were: rents (0.3%) and new dwelling purchases (0.2%). The TM distribution ranged from −0.38% to 0.82%.
- Today's inflation update revealed price discounting for some durable goods as retail demand softens. We would expect to see a bounce from these categories in the following month. There was also offsetting strength elsewhere in durable good so at least for now, the momentum continues to suggest some near term upside risk to our current inflation estimates.
- Nevertheless, as the TM came in on expectations and based on a first quick pass at updating the quarterly profile, we see little pressure to revise our current Q3 estimates of 1.3%qtr for the CPI and 0.9%qtr for the TM.
- The RBA remains alert to near term inflationary risks. We are expecting the momentum in TM inflation to remain well above the top of the target band through to year-end underpinning our expectations for the RBA to raise rates again in November.

Monthly inflation



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics

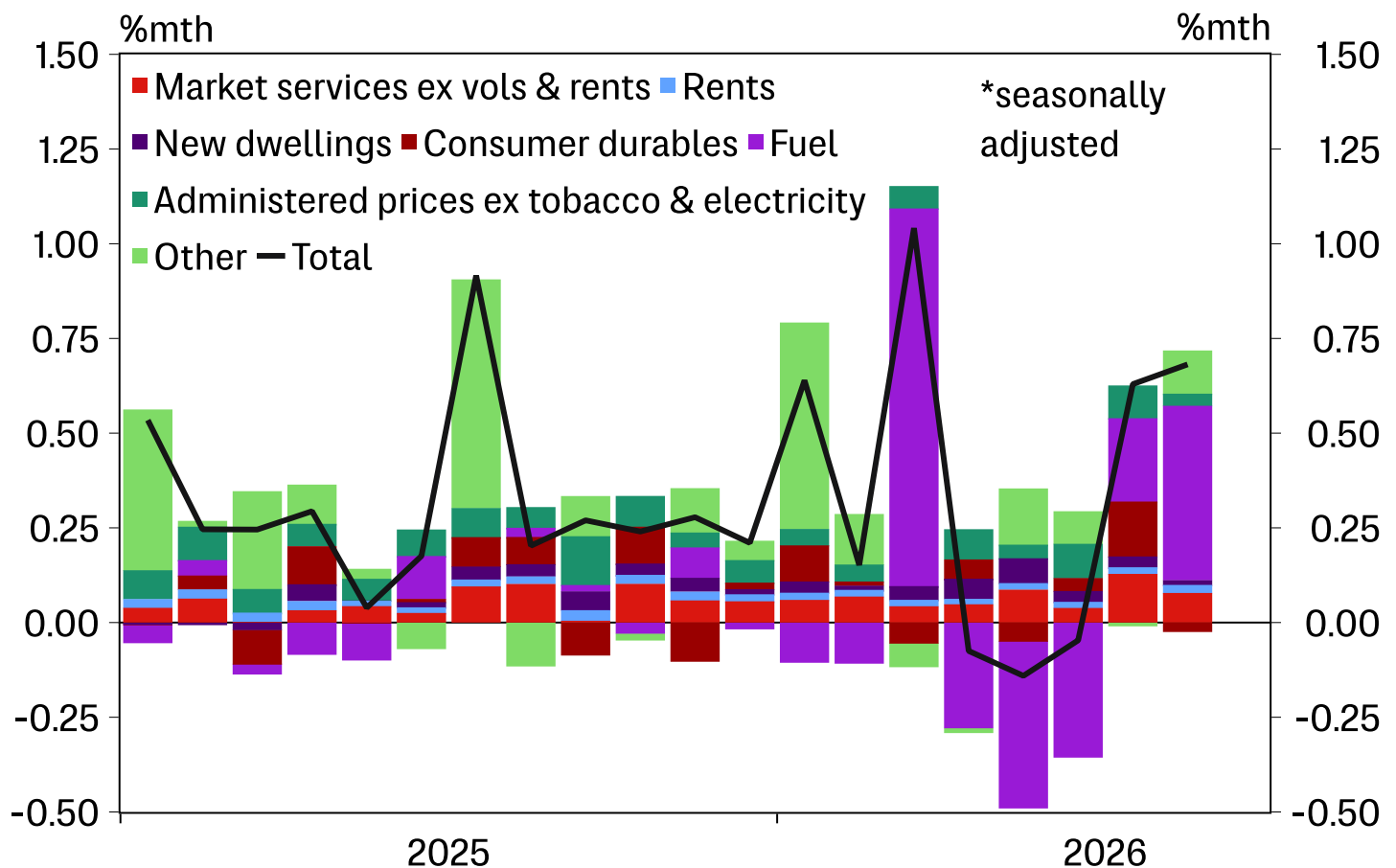


August CPI in more detail

Following the bumper read in July, the monthly CPI moderated in August rising 0.4%*mt*. This was in line with our expectations and slightly softer than the market consensus. This took the year-ended pace to 4.0%*yr*. On a seasonally adjusted basis the CPI rose 0.7%*mt* highlighting the impact of seasonal sales in August.

The key drivers behind the monthly lift were automotive fuel, up 14.8%*mt*, contributing 0.5ppts to the headline figure. The surge resulted from the ending of the fuel excise discount on August 3 and rising global energy prices. With crude oil prices still elevated due to the conflict in the middle east, and growing shortages of refined products due to both the middle east conflict and Ukrainian assaults on Russian refining capacity, auto fuel is expected to remain an inflationary impulse at least until the end of 2026.

Contribution to monthly CPI inflation



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics



The monthly TM also softened, rising 0.2%*mt* compared to the 0.5%*mt* read from July. The result was again in line with our expectations, and very close at two decimal places (0.24%*mt* vs 0.23%*mt*), but softer than the market's view. The year-ended pace held at 3.6%*yr* for the third consecutive month, although it continued to ease marginally at the second decimal place. In contrast, the six-month annualised pace has continued to trend higher since April and is currently running at 3.9%*yr*.

There is a possibility that as the ABS continues to grapple with seasonal adjustment issues we will see revisions to the TM estimates. Last July also saw a strong 0.48%^{mth} read which eased to 0.29%^{mth} in August. This is not too dissimilar from the 0.48%^{mth} and 0.24%^{mth} reads for 2026.

We are expecting core inflation to start to moderate as we get to year end but our current estimate for the month of December still has the TM running at a 3.3% in the year while the six-month annualised pace is still a chunky 3.1%. Applying a trim on the seasonally adjusted 3m/3m expenditure classes yields a TM of 0.9%^{qtr} currently. This is in line with our current Q3 TM estimate.

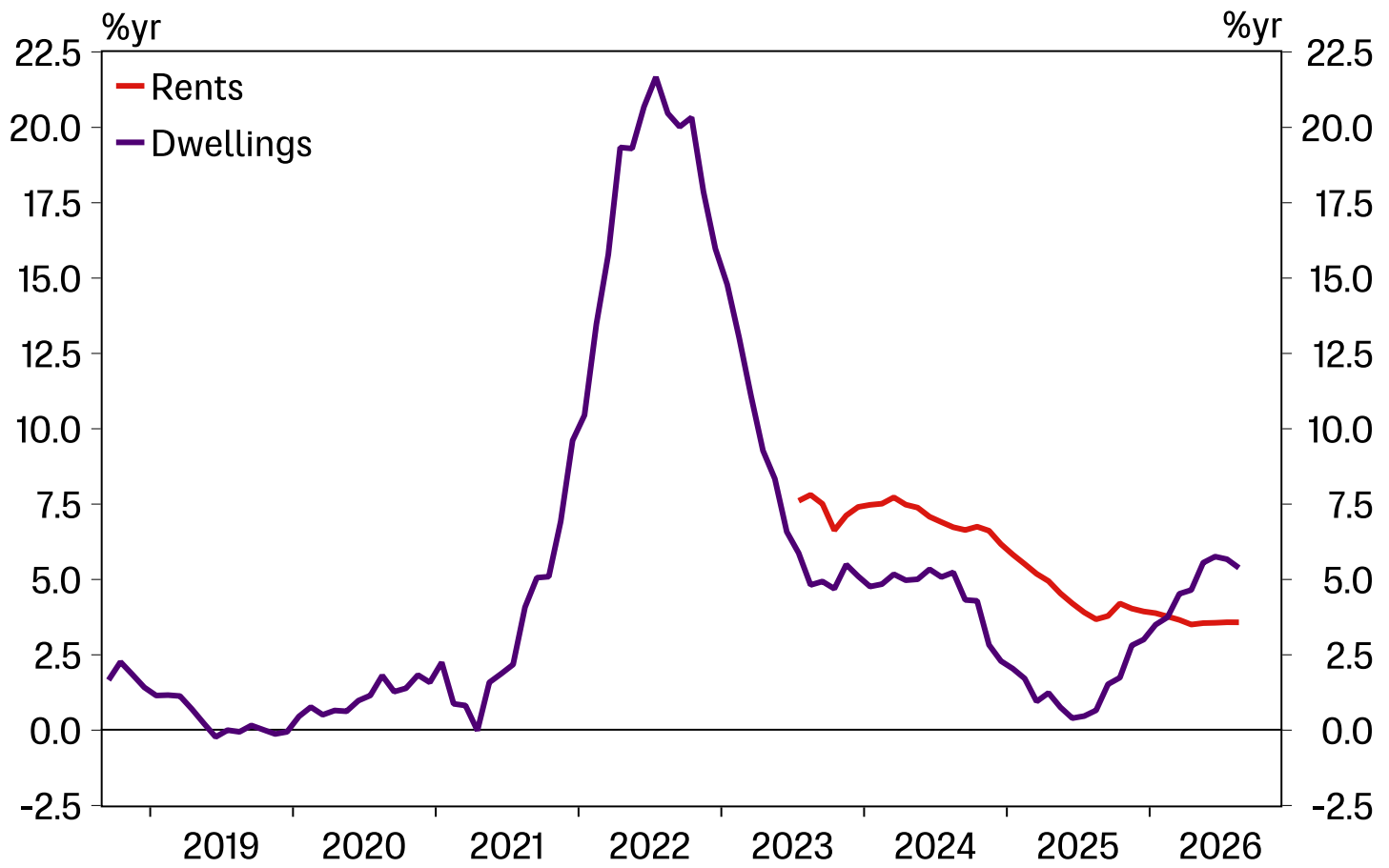
Other measures of underlying inflation told a similar story, easing on a monthly basis but holding steady on a year-ended basis. Market services ex volatiles fell -0.4%^{mth} to be 3.3%^{yr} higher. Excluding both volatiles & holidays saw a 0.2%^{mth}/4.1%^{yr} lift.

Most market services components eased in the month (including on a seasonally adjusted basis) but annual growth across this group as a whole remained above the RBA's 2-3% target band. The near-term momentum (three-month annualised) is also quite strong across several components of services. Of note include deposit and loan facilities (11.2%^{mth}), sports participation (10.9%), clothing repair (7.0%), restaurant meals (6.8%) and other household services (5.2%). We are closely watching market services as this is where inflationary risks, outside of energy, appear to be most persistent.

Due to its sizable weight in the CPI, and the fact price changes here tend to be less volatile than many other categories, so they almost always appear in the TM estimates, housing prices remain a key focus. Rents rose 0.3%^{mth} in August, in line with our expectations, to be up 3.6%^{yr}. Since April, the seasonally adjusted rents series has been running lower than the non-seasonally adjusted series. We are expecting rents to hold around this pace till year end before moderating modestly as we move through 2027.

New dwellings inflation was 0.2%^{mth} in August (softer than our expectation for a 0.4%^{mth} rise). Since peaking in May, monthly price growth has slowed in each successive month, potentially reflecting increasing difficulty for developers in passing through higher costs amid softer conditions in established housing markets and weaker demand in the face of higher interest rates. The annual pace looks to have topped out. It was at 5.8%^{yr} in June easing to 5.4%^{yr} currently with the three-month annualised pace at 3.7%. We expect dwelling price inflation to continue easing through to the end of 2027 as falling established house prices limit the ability of builders to pass on rising construction costs. There is a medium-term risk that as conditions improve builders may raise prices more aggressively to claw back margins.

Housing inflation – rents and dwellings



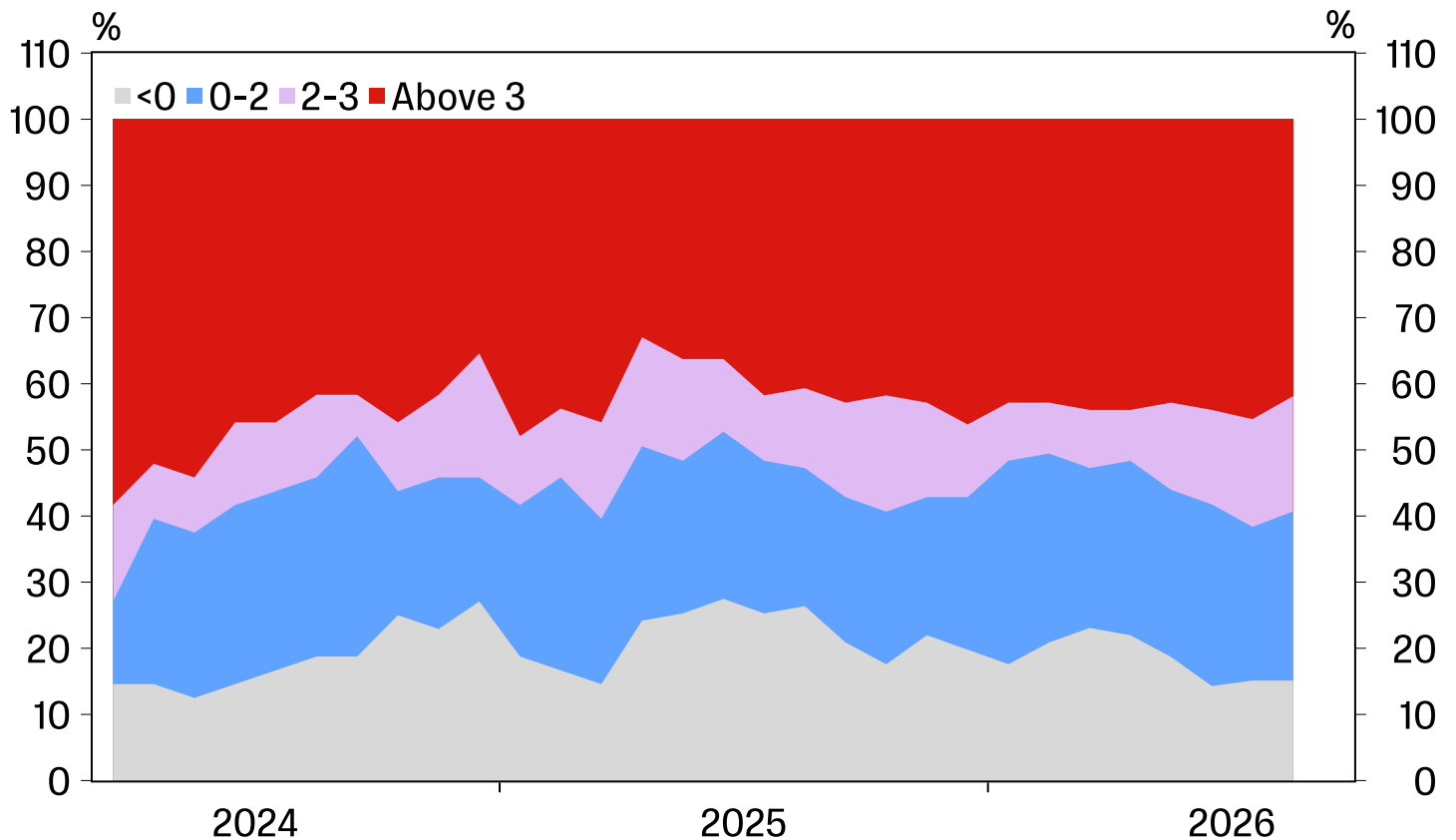
Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics



Overall, the breadth of inflation moderated in August. The share of the basket running above 3%yr eased from 45% to 42%, with the share below 2%yr increasing from 38% to 41%.

Inflation Sub-Categories

Year-ended, Share of Basket



Source: ABS, Macrobond, Westpac Economics



Key surprises in the month:

Upside surprises

- Insurance surprised to the upside (0.7%*mt* vs 0.3%*mt*) after a run of weaker-than-usual reads over the past two months.
- Motor vehicle repair costs rose a solid 0.8% against our 0.3%*mt* expectations, with spare parts and accessories also up 0.3%*mt* vs -0.4%*mt*.
- Footwear rose 1.7%*mt* against our expectations for a -2.9%*mt* decline, the gains were broad-based across women, men & children.
- Household goods surprised to the upside. Household appliances, utensils and tools rose 1.9%*mt* against our flat expectations, meanwhile household textiles fell -1.0%*mt* against our expectations for a -5.0%*mt* fall. Furniture and furnishings also fell by less than expected -0.6%*mt* vs -1.3%*mt*.
- Recreation and culture surprised to the upside (-1.0%*mt* vs -1.5%*mt*), owing to a 1.4%*mt* lift in other recreation, sport & culture against our expectations for a flat read on the back of an outsized gain in games, toys & hobbies (10.2%*mt* vs 2.5%*mt*). Holiday travel was marginally less weak than expected (-3.3% vs -3.5%*mt*).

Downside surprises

- Food was the key downside miss falling -0.1% mth against our expectations for a 0.2% mth lift. Meat & seafood (-0.9% mth vs 0.5% mth) and fruit & vegetables (-1.2% mth vs 0.1% mth) were the key areas of weakness.
- Audio, visual and computing equipment and services came in weaker-than-expected (0.7% mth vs 1.2% mth), owing to a softer 0.6% mth lift in computing services (3.0% mth expected). This was partly balanced by a stronger than expected lift in computing equipment (0.9% mth vs -0.5% mth). The latter is where we are most likely to see the impact of the AI boom in the CPI, due to computer chip inflation, other than construction cost inflation for new dwellings.
- Motor vehicles came in lower at -0.4% mth vs -0.1% mth which could be the start of price pressures associated with the rapid expansion of the share of Chinese cars in the Australian market. Automotive fuel was also slightly softer at 14.8% mth vs 16.7% mth.
- Garments and accessories were both softer. Garments fell -1.9% mth against our expectations for a 0.2% mth rise, meanwhile accessories came in at 0.1% mth vs 0.5% mth expected.

CPI Item	Qtr CPI		Monthly CPI		WBC fcs
	Jun-26 % qtr	Jun-26 % mth	Jul-26 % mth	Aug-26 % mth	Aug-26 % mth
Food	1.0	0.4	0.3	-0.1	0.2
of which, bread & cereals	0.0	0.7	-0.3	0.0	0.4
of which, meat & seafood	0.8	-0.3	0.2	-0.9	0.5
of which, dairy & related products	2.1	1.3	0.2	-0.1	0.3
of which, fruit & vegetables	3.4	1.0	-0.8	-1.1	0.1
of which, food products nec	-0.7	-0.2	0.0	0.3	0.4
of which, non-alcohol beverages	1.6	1.0	0.0	0.3	-0.4
Alcohol & tobacco	0.5	-0.5	1.2	0.5	0.1
of which, Alcohol	0.1	-0.7	1.2	0.5	0.2
of which, Tobacco	1.5	0.0	1.2	0.5	0.0
Clothing & footwear	1.1	-1.0	2.6	-0.9	-0.1
of which, garments	0.7	-3.1	3.2	-1.9	0.2
Housing	0.9	0.5	0.4	0.2	0.3
of which, Rents	0.8	0.3	0.4	0.3	0.3
of which, House purchases	1.8	0.4	0.4	0.2	0.4
of which, Electricity	0.3	0.7	-1.6	0.0	-0.7
of which, Gas & other fuels	-1.9	2.7	2.8	0.0	2.6
H/hold contents & services	0.1	-4.2	4.4	0.2	0.0
Health	2.2	-0.1	0.1	0.1	0.0
Transportation	-0.7	-2.7	2.6	4.2	4.5
of which, auto fuel	-2.1	-10.9	7.5	14.8	16.6
Communication	0.6	-0.7	1.8	-0.2	0.0
Recreation	-0.4	1.8	1.8	-1.0	-1.5
of which, holiday travel	-1.0	4.6	1.8	-3.3	-3.5
Education	1.5	0.0	0.0	0.1	0.1
Financial & insurance services	0.9	0.5	0.2	0.2	0.1
CPI: All groups %qtr/%mth	0.6	-0.1	1.0	0.4	0.4
Trimmed Mean: %qtr/%mth	0.8	0.3	0.5	0.2	0.2

What does this mean for the RBA?

Yesterday, post the RBA rate hike and monetary policy decision statement, Westpac changed its view from a November follow up rate hike being a risk to being the base case. The post-meeting statement was notable for its emphasis on the Middle East conflict, noting that “global energy prices are now much higher than had been assumed in the August forecasts”. In addition, RBA’s liaison suggests firms are passing this on or planning to do so. The pass-through was characterised as partial, and additional to domestically driven inflation arising from capacity pressures. We read this as implying that the RBA is concerned about upside risks to underlying inflation in Q4 of this year, as well as Q3.

Our current forecast of 0.9%qtr for the September quarter TM stands post today's release and represents a step up from 0.8% in the June quarter holding the annual pace at 3.6%yr. Our current forecast for the Q4 TM is 0.7%qtr/3.3%yr but given the move in energy prices, and anecdotes of firms now passing on those rising costs, we too see upside risks to this estimate.

As such, we hold to the view that the RBA will follow up with another rate hike in November. For more information on the RBA decision please see Luci Ellis's note "[RBA hikes in September, November follow-up now expected](#)".

Stay informed with Westpac IQ

Get the latest reports straight to your inbox.

Subscribe

Related articles

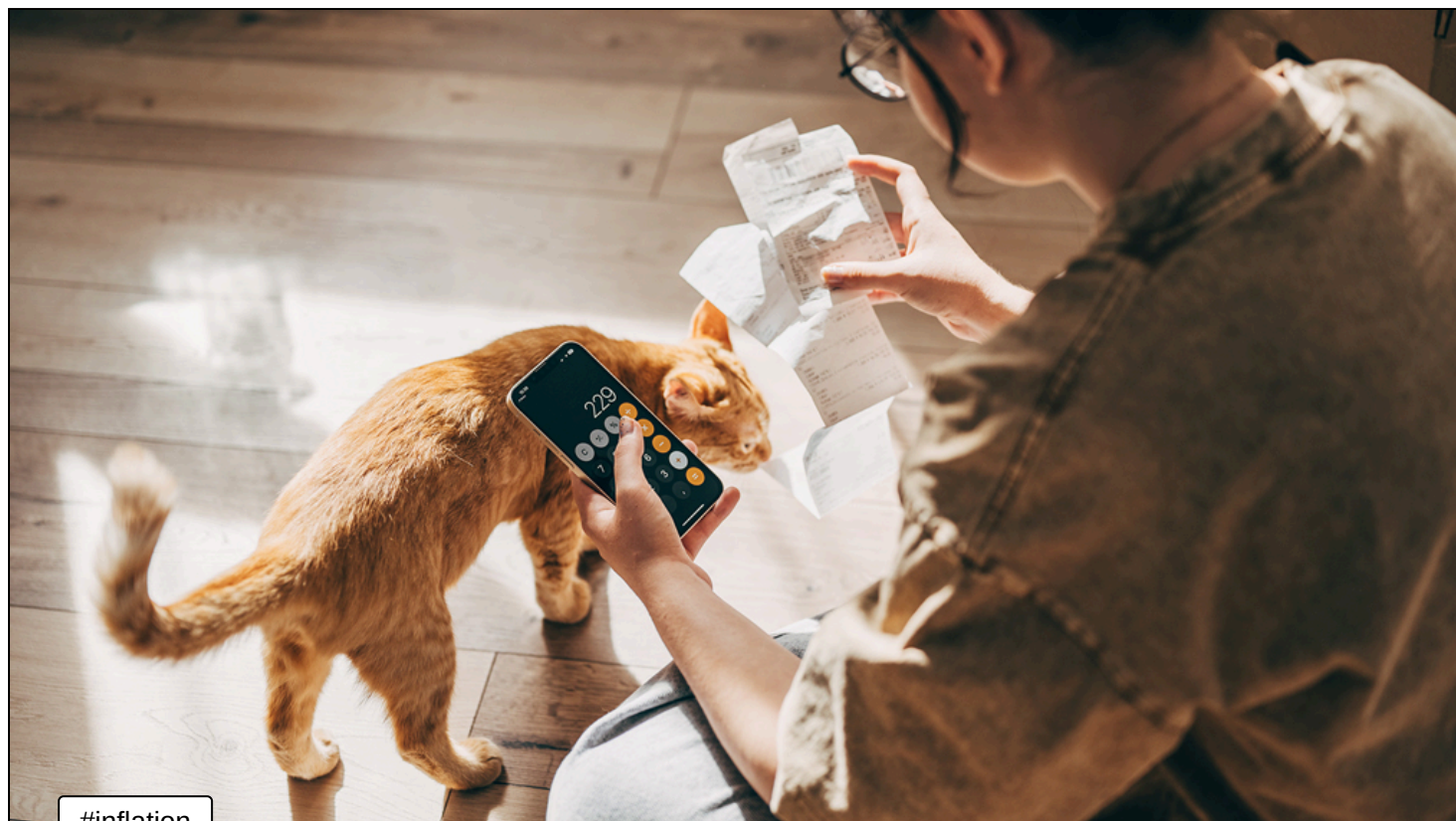


#inflation

Persistent sources of inflation and the RBNZ

October 01 2026 • ⌚ 3 mins

By [Satish Ranchhod](#)



#inflation

First impressions: NZ selected prices August 2026

September 18 2026 • ⌚ 2 mins

By [Satish Ranchhod](#)



#inflation

August CPI: preview and analysis

September 14 2026 • ⌚ 5 mins

By [Justin Smirk](#) & [Neha Sharma](#)

Browse topics

#aud

#australia

#interestrates

#nzd

#usd

#newzealand

#rates

#credit

#yieldcurve

#acgb

#inflation

#semigovernment

#rba

#basis

#commodities

#ustreasury

#fx

#jpy

#rbnz

#abs

Show more tags

Disclaimer

©2026 Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 (including where acting under any of its Westpac, St George, Bank of Melbourne or BankSA brands, collectively, “Westpac”). References to the “Westpac Group” are to Westpac and its subsidiaries and includes the directors, employees and representatives of Westpac and its subsidiaries.

Things you should know

We respect your privacy: You can view the [New Zealand Privacy Policy](#) here, or the [Australian Group Privacy Statement](#) here. Each time someone visits our site, data is captured so that we can accurately evaluate the quality of our content and make improvements for you. We may at times use technology to capture data about you to help us to better understand you and your needs, including potentially for the purposes of assessing your individual reading habits and interests to allow us to provide suggestions regarding other reading material which may be suitable for you.

This information, unless specifically indicated otherwise, is under copyright of the Westpac Group. None of the material, nor its contents, nor any copy of it, may be altered in any way, transmitted to, copied or distributed to any other party without the prior written permission of the Westpac Group.

Disclaimer

This information has been prepared by Westpac and is intended for information purposes only. It is not intended to reflect any recommendation or financial advice and investment decisions should not be based on it. This information does not constitute an offer, a solicitation of an offer, or an inducement to subscribe for, purchase or sell any financial instrument or to enter into a legally binding contract. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the advice. Certain types of transactions, including those involving futures, options and high yield securities give rise to substantial risk and are not suitable for all investors. We recommend that you seek your own independent legal or financial advice before proceeding with any investment decision.

This information may contain material provided by third parties. While such material is published with the necessary permission none of Westpac or its related entities accepts any responsibility for the accuracy or completeness of any such material. Although we have made every effort to ensure this information is free from error, none of Westpac or its related entities warrants the accuracy, adequacy or completeness of this information, or otherwise endorses it in any way. Except where contrary to law, Westpac Group intend by this notice to exclude liability for this information. This information is subject to change without notice and none of Westpac or its related entities is under any obligation to update this information or correct any inaccuracy which may become apparent at a later date. This information may contain or incorporate by reference forward-looking statements. The words “believe”, “anticipate”, “expect”, “intend”, “plan”, “predict”, “continue”, “assume”, “positioned”, “may”, “will”, “should”, “shall”, “risk” and other similar expressions that are predictions of or indicate future events and future trends identify forward-looking statements. These forward-

looking statements include all matters that are not historical facts. Past performance is not a reliable indicator of future performance, nor are forecasts of future performance. Whilst every effort has been taken to ensure that the assumptions on which any forecasts are based are reasonable, the forecasts may be affected by incorrect assumptions or by known or unknown risks and uncertainties. The ultimate outcomes may differ substantially from any forecasts.

Conflicts of Interest: In the normal course of offering banking products and services to its clients, the Westpac Group may act in several capacities (including issuer, market maker, underwriter, distributor, swap counterparty and calculation agent) simultaneously with respect to a financial instrument, giving rise to potential conflicts of interest which may impact the performance of a financial instrument. The Westpac Group may at any time transact or hold a position (including hedging and trading positions) for its own account or the account of a client in any financial instrument which may impact the performance of that financial instrument.

Author(s) disclaimer and declaration: The author(s) confirms that (a) no part of his/her compensation was, is, or will be, directly or indirectly, related to any views or (if applicable) recommendations expressed in this material; (b) this material accurately reflects his/her personal views about the financial products, companies or issuers (if applicable) and is based on sources reasonably believed to be reliable and accurate; (c) to the best of the author's knowledge, they are not in receipt of inside information and this material does not contain inside information; and (d) no other part of the Westpac Group has made any attempt to influence this material.

Further important information regarding sustainability-related content: This material may contain statements relating to environmental, social and governance (ESG) topics. These are subject to known and unknown risks, and there are significant uncertainties, limitations, risks and assumptions in the metrics, modelling, data, scenarios, reporting and analysis on which the statements rely. In particular, these areas are rapidly evolving and maturing, and there are variations in approaches and common standards and practice, as well as uncertainty around future related policy and legislation. Some material may include information derived from publicly available sources that have not been independently verified. No representation or warranty is made as to the accuracy, completeness or reliability of the information. There is a risk that the analysis, estimates, judgements, assumptions, views, models, scenarios or projections used may turn out to be incorrect. These risks may cause actual outcomes to differ materially from those expressed or implied. The ESG-related statements in this material do not constitute advice, nor are they guarantees or predictions of future performance, and Westpac gives no representation, warranty or assurance (including as to the quality, accuracy or completeness of the statements). You should seek your own independent advice.

Additional country disclosures:

Australia: Westpac holds an Australian Financial Services Licence (No. 233714). You can access Westpac's Financial Services Guide [here](#) or request a copy from your Westpac point of contact. To the extent that this information contains any general advice, it has been prepared without taking into account your objectives, financial situation or needs and before acting on it you should consider the

appropriateness of the advice.

New Zealand: In New Zealand, Westpac Institutional Bank refers to the brand under which products and services are provided by either Westpac (NZ division) or Westpac New Zealand Limited (company number 1763882), the New Zealand incorporated subsidiary of Westpac ("WNZL"). Any product or service made available by WNZL does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WNZL). Neither Westpac nor its other subsidiaries guarantee or otherwise support the performance of WNZL in respect of any such product. WNZL is not an authorised deposit-taking institution for the purposes of Australian prudential standards. The current disclosure statements for the New Zealand branch of Westpac and WNZL can be obtained at the internet address www.westpac.co.nz.

Singapore: This material has been prepared and issued for distribution in Singapore to institutional investors, accredited investors and expert investors (as defined in the applicable Singapore laws and regulations) only. Recipients of this material in Singapore should contact Westpac Singapore Branch in respect of any matters arising from, or in connection with, this material. Westpac Singapore Branch holds a wholesale banking licence and is subject to supervision by the Monetary Authority of Singapore.

Fiji: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac Fiji are available from www.westpac.com.fj © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia and registered as a branch in Fiji. The liability of its members is limited.

Papua New Guinea: Unless otherwise specified, the products and services for Westpac PNG are available from www.westpac.com.pg © Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141. This information does not take your personal circumstances into account and before acting on it you should consider the appropriateness of the information for your financial situation. Westpac Banking Corporation ABN 33 007 457 141 is incorporated in NSW Australia. Westpac is represented in Papua New Guinea by Westpac Bank - PNG - Limited. The liability of its members is limited.

U.S.: Westpac operates in the United States of America as a federally licensed branch, regulated by the Office of the Comptroller of the Currency. Westpac is also registered with the US Commodity Futures Trading Commission ("CFTC") as a Swap Dealer, but is neither registered as, or affiliated with, a Futures Commission Merchant registered with the US CFTC. The services and products referenced above are not insured by the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation ("FDIC"). Westpac Capital Markets, LLC ('WCM'), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Westpac, is a broker-dealer registered under the U.S. Securities Exchange Act of 1934 ('the Exchange Act') and member of the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority ('FINRA'). In accordance with APRA's Prudential Standard 222 'Association with Related Entities', Westpac does not stand behind WCM other than as provided for in certain legal agreements between Westpac and WCM and obligations of WCM do not represent

liabilities of Westpac.

This communication is provided for distribution to U.S. institutional investors in reliance on the exemption from registration provided by Rule 15a-6 under the Exchange Act and is not subject to all of the independence and disclosure standards applicable to debt research reports prepared for retail investors in the United States. WCM is the U.S. distributor of this communication and accepts responsibility for the contents of this communication. Transactions by U.S. customers of any securities referenced herein should be effected through WCM. All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WCM. If you would like to speak to someone regarding any security mentioned herein, please contact WCM on +1 212 389 1269. Investing in any non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments mentioned in this communication may present certain risks. The securities of non-U.S. issuers may not be registered with, or be subject to the regulations of, the SEC in the United States. Information on such non-U.S. securities or related financial instruments may be limited. Non-U.S. companies may not be subject to audit and reporting standards and regulatory requirements comparable to those in effect in the United States. The value of any investment or income from any securities or related derivative instruments denominated in a currency other than U.S. dollars is subject to exchange rate fluctuations that may have a positive or adverse effect on the value of or income from such securities or related derivative instruments.

The author of this communication is employed by Westpac and is not registered or qualified as a research analyst, representative, or associated person of WCM or any other U.S. broker-dealer under the rules of FINRA, any other U.S. self-regulatory organisation, or the laws, rules or regulations of any State. Unless otherwise specifically stated, the views expressed herein are solely those of the author and may differ from the information, views or analysis expressed by Westpac and/or its affiliates.

UK: The London branch of Westpac is authorised in the United Kingdom by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and is subject to regulation by the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) and limited regulation by the PRA (Financial Services Register number: 124586). The London branch of Westpac is registered at Companies House as a branch established in the United Kingdom (Branch No. BR000106). Details about the extent of the regulation of Westpac's London branch by the PRA are available from us on request.

This communication is not being made to or distributed to, and must not be passed on to, the general public in the United Kingdom. Rather, this communication is being made only to and is directed at (a) those persons falling within the definition of Investment Professionals (set out in Article 19(5) of the Financial Services and Markets Act 2000 (Financial Promotion) Order 2005 (the "Order")); (b) those persons falling within the definition of high net worth companies, unincorporated associations etc. (set out in Article 49(2) of the Order; (c) other persons to whom it may lawfully be communicated in accordance with the Order or (d) any persons to whom it may otherwise lawfully be made (all such persons together being referred to as "relevant persons"). Any person who is not a relevant person should not act or rely on this communication or any of its contents. In the same way, the information contained in this communication is intended for "eligible counterparties" and

“professional clients” as defined by the rules of the Financial Conduct Authority and is not intended for “retail clients”. Westpac expressly prohibits you from passing on the information in this communication to any third party.

European Economic Area (“EEA”): This material may be distributed to you by either: (i) Westpac directly, or (ii) Westpac Europe GmbH (“WEG”) under a sub-licensing arrangement. WEG has not edited or otherwise modified the content of this material. WEG is authorised in Germany by the Federal Financial Supervision Authority (‘BaFin’) and subject to its regulation. WEG’s supervisory authorities are BaFin and the German Federal Bank (‘Deutsche Bundesbank’). WEG is registered with the commercial register (‘Handelsregister’) of the local court of Frankfurt am Main under registration number HRB 118483. In accordance with APRA’s Prudential Standard 222 ‘Association with Related Entities’, Westpac does not stand behind WEG other than as provided for in certain legal agreements (a risk transfer, sub-participation and collateral agreement) between Westpac and WEG and obligations of WEG do not represent liabilities of Westpac. Any product or service made available by WEG does not represent an offer from Westpac or any of its subsidiaries (other than WEG). All disclaimers set out with respect to Westpac apply equally to WEG.

This communication is not intended for distribution to, or use by any person or entity in any jurisdiction or country where such distribution or use would be contrary to local law or regulation.

This communication contains general commentary, research, and market colour. The communication does not constitute investment advice. The material may contain an ‘investment recommendation’ and/or ‘information recommending or suggesting an investment’, both as defined in Regulation (EU) No 596/2014 (including as applicable in the United Kingdom) (“MAR”). In accordance with the relevant provisions of MAR, reasonable care has been taken to ensure that the material has been objectively presented and that interests or conflicts of interest of the sender concerning the financial instruments to which that information relates have been disclosed.

Investment recommendations must be read alongside the specific disclosure which accompanies them and the general disclosure which can be found [here](#). Such disclosure fulfils certain additional information requirements of MAR and associated delegated legislation and by accepting this communication you acknowledge that you are aware of the existence of such additional disclosure and its contents.

To the extent this communication comprises an investment recommendation it is classified as non-independent research. It has not been prepared in accordance with legal requirements designed to promote the independence of investment research and therefore constitutes a marketing communication. Further, this communication is not subject to any prohibition on dealing ahead of the dissemination of investment research.